THE NOBULOUS SET · GAME ONE

Build-a-Tyrant (BAT)

Four scientists, one boss, and every failure makes it stronger.

Four Lab Rats work their benches in Nobulous' laboratory, resolving Encounters and bolting salvaged Upgrades onto themselves. Every Encounter they fail donates material to the thing growing in the tank. Five Splices and it wakes up. Then they have to kill it.

COMPONENTS

- 4 double-sided Lab Rat cards
- 20 Encounter cards
- 16 regular Upgrade cards (4 each of Power, Mobility, Defense, Senses)
- 8 Specimen cards
- 7 Tyrant Attack cards
- 1 Buff HP track card (12 spaces)
- **From 20 Strong:** the 17 unit dice — 4 Purple, 4 Blue, 4 Green, 4 Yellow, 1 Red
- **From 20 Strong:** the **Strategy die**, which marks the active Lab Rat all game; the **Health die**, which is used for the Tyrant track in the battle; the **Health dial**; and the Chip. The Recovery die is not used.

SETUP

1. Choose one side for each of the four Lab Rat cards. That side is fixed for the game. Place all four Rats in a row — every Rat is in play at once.
2. Give each Rat one Purple, one Blue, one Green and one Yellow die. These are that Rat's **personal dice** and stay at their own workbench.
3. Place the Red die on a randomly selected Lab Rat. Red is communal and belongs to no Rat.
4. Set the dial to 20; this is the Tyrant's base Health.
5. Choose a difficulty level. This corresponds to a) the number of **Specimens** to be added to the Upgrade deck and b) the Tyrant's **Buff HP**.

DIFFICULTY	SPECIMENS	BUFF HP	WIN RATE
Easy	4	4	~70%
Standard	5	5	~63%
Hard	6	6	~56%
Brutal	7	7	~49%
Nobulous	8	8	~42%

Shuffle that many random Specimens in with the 16 regular Upgrades. Return the rest to the box.

6. Shuffle the 20 Encounters into a face-down deck. Leave room beside it for the **Tyrant Splices** and the **Tyrant Attack deck**.

OBJECT OF THE GAME

The game is split into two parts: the **Splice Phase** and the **Tyrant Battle**. Five Splices awaken the Tyrant. You cannot avoid this — the game is about *which* five cards it gets and *what shape your Rats are in* when it stands up. Defeat the Tyrant to win.

THE SPLICE PHASE (A TURN)

1. Reveal the next Encounter card.
2. Reveal 2 cards from the Upgrade deck. If either is a Specimen, increase this Encounter's Target by **+1** (once only, even if both are Specimens).
3. Choose which Rat is active and put the **Strategy die** on it *after* seeing the Encounter and the two Upgrades. The same Rat may be chosen on consecutive turns.
4. Resolve any ability that triggers after selection but before dice are committed.
5. Commit dice, roll, and resolve (below).
6. Exhaust the committed personal dice, resolve Red and any borrowed die, then recover dice equal to that Rat's REC.

Committing and rolling

The active Rat may commit any number of its own available dice, plus Red if it holds it, plus at most one borrowed die. Hits and Crits count toward the Encounter Target.

> **SUCCESS**
>
> Roll successes greater than or equal to the Target value and satisfy any printed restriction. The active Rat takes **one** of the two revealed Upgrades (max 3 Upgrades per Rat). Discard the other.

FAILURE

Splice the stronger revealed Upgrade into the Tyrant — add it face-up to the **Tyrant Splices** stacked beside the Tyrant Attack deck. Discard the other. If the two are equal in Value, choose randomly.

Zero-dice turns

A Rat may be selected and commit nothing. The Encounter fails automatically and the stronger Upgrade is Spliced. Recovery still happens. This is a legal choice, not a rest action — it gives no bonus.

UPGRADES

Every Upgrade card includes three elements: a **category** (Power, Mobility, Defense or Senses), a **Value**, and a printed **tap effect**.

- During the **Splice Phase**, the Value indicates which of two revealed cards is the *stronger* one — the one that gets Spliced when you fail. Holding Upgrades also narrows what you may borrow.
- During the **Tyrant Battle**, the Value determines how much damage the card can absorb before it is destroyed. Tapping a card (Rats only) uses its printed effect. The Tyrant's Splices and the Rats' Upgrades take damage differently — see *Armor* below.
- A Rat may hold at most **3** Upgrades. Specimens count against that limit.

The Tyrant holds Spliced Upgrades differently. It never taps: the **frontmost** Splice in its row applies its effect on every attack, free, for as long as that card survives — so a Splice is armor and a weapon at the same time, and killing it is how you switch off both.

BORROWING

The active Rat may borrow **one** available non-Red die from another Rat. The more Upgrades the borrower already holds, the worse the die it is allowed to take:

UPGRADES HELD	MAY BORROW	BANISH RISK
0	Purple, Blue, Green or Yellow	17%
1	Blue, Green or Yellow	33%
2	Green or Yellow	50%
3	Yellow only	67%

After the Encounter resolves, roll the borrowed die by itself. On a miss it is **banished** — removed from the game permanently. On a hit or Crit it returns to its owner exhausted.

THE RED DIE

- Red is communal, is never banished, and belongs to no workbench.
- If the active Rat holds Red, it may commit it normally.
- After Red is used it is **set aside** rather than exhausted.
- At the start of the next turn, after the active Rat has been chosen, place the set-aside Red on any **non-active** Rat.

During the Tyrant Battle the Red die works differently. It is not included in the shared pool, nor is it passed around. **The attacking Rat may commit it, but only if they do not tap an Upgrade as part of the attack.** The Red die is set aside afterwards instead of being exhausted.

AWAKENING THE TYRANT

The Tyrant awakens the moment it reaches **5 Splices**. Build the **Tyrant track**; from left to right, place the **Buff HP card** with the Health die on the spot corresponding to your chosen difficulty level, the five Tyrant Splices **in a random order**, and then the **Health dial (set to 20)**. Once complete, begin the battle.

Splicing Machine Malfunction. If the Encounter deck runs out first, randomly select enough unused Upgrade cards to bring the Tyrant to exactly 5 Splices, apply them, and begin the battle. Running out of *Upgrade* cards is not a malfunction — reshuffle the Upgrade discard instead.

THE TYRANT BATTLE

Setting up the fight

1. The **Tyrant track** runs Buff HP, the five shuffled Splices, Health. That is the order damage has to chew through, and the **Health die walks along it** — it starts on the Buff HP card and only ever moves right, sitting on whichever card is currently being damaged and showing how much that card has taken. One die runs the whole Tyrant.
2. The Tyrant has **20 Health** plus its Buff HP, and a dice pool of **2 Purple, 2 Blue, 1 Green and 1 Yellow**. Those six dice never exhaust — the Tyrant draws from them fresh every round. Keep them in a bag or a cup you can reach into without looking.
3. Sweep every personal die still in the game — from all four Rats, available *and* exhausted — into one **shared battle pool**, all available. Banished dice stay gone. **Red is not part of the pool**; it is available to the attacking Rat every round, on the terms described under *The Red die*.
4. Each Rat keeps its own Health, its own Upgrades and its own ability. Shuffle the 7 Tyrant Attack cards into a face-down deck.

A battle round

1. **Untap.** Every Upgrade tapped last round untaps now.
2. **Choose the attacking Rat** from those still standing and move the **Strategy die** to it. It uses its own ability and its own Upgrades.
3. **Commit up to 6 dice** from the shared battle pool and roll them. **Reroll each miss once** — that is the Rats' STR 2. Every hit is 1 damage and every Crit is 2.
4. **Either tap one Upgrade or commit Red — not both.** Tapping applies that Upgrade's printed effect, and the card cannot absorb damage until it untaps. Committing Red adds it to the roll on top of your six pool dice, for free. A Rat may of course do neither.
5. **Apply the damage** to the Tyrant along its row: **Buff HP first**, then its Defense Splices, then its remaining Splices, then its Health. Each Splice soaks damage up to its Value and is destroyed once that Value is used up; anything left over carries straight through to the next card.
6. **Recover.** Return dice equal to the attacking Rat's **REC + 1** from the ones you just committed to the shared pool. **The rest are exhausted and do not come back.**
7. If the Tyrant is at 0 Health, the Rats win. Otherwise the Tyrant attacks.

The Tyrant's attack

1. Reveal the top **Tyrant Attack** card and apply it. Discard it afterwards; reshuffle the discard if the deck runs out.
2. The Tyrant draws a number of dice equal to the **highest Value among the Splices it still holds** — 2 if it holds none, never more than its 6 — **at random, without looking**, and rolls them. Return them to the bag afterwards. Hits and Crits are damage as usual.
3. Add the effect of the **frontmost Splice in the row**. The Tyrant never taps: the effect is free, it happens on every attack, and it uses the card's **printed Value** — damage already marked on that card does not weaken it. When the frontmost Splice is destroyed the next one takes over.
4. Unless the card says otherwise the attack lands on the **attacking Rat**. Choose one of that Rat's *untapped* Upgrades: if the damage **meets or exceeds its Value** the Upgrade is destroyed and the rest carries on to the next Upgrade under the same test, then to Health. If the damage cannot meet any remaining Upgrade's Value, **it stops there** — the Upgrade holds and nothing reaches Health. A Rat's Upgrade is never left part-damaged.
5. A Rat reduced to 0 Health is **knocked out**: set it aside and discard its Upgrades. It cannot be chosen as the attacker again, and for the campaign its Upgrades become candidates rather than retained cards.

Reduce the Tyrant to 0 Health to win. If every Rat is knocked out, the Tyrant wins and you replay BAT.

Armor

> **TWO KINDS OF ARMOR**
>
> **The Tyrant's Splices accumulate damage** — the Health die sits on whichever one is being chewed through and remembers how far you have got. **A Rat's Upgrades do not.** A blow either meets an Upgrade's Value and shatters it or bounces off it entirely, so no Rat card is ever left part-damaged.

Buff HP

Buff HP must be removed before any damage reaches the Tyrant's 20 Health. The track runs 12 down to 0; the five gold spaces are the difficulty numbers — 4 to 8. Put the **Health die** on your difficulty's number and move it one space for each point of damage. When it reaches DEAD the Buff HP is gone — move the die onto the first Splice and carry on. You may set the die anywhere on the track, up to 12, to tune the difficulty beyond the five listed rungs.

CARRYING BAT FORWARD

Only relevant if you are playing the Nobulous Research Journal (NRJ) campaign. Skip otherwise.

After a successful battle, **retain up to 3 Upgrade cards held by Rats that survived**, of which at most 1 may be a Specimen. Upgrades held by knocked-out Rats, and every card spliced into the Tyrant, become **candidates**. If fewer than 3 eligible Upgrades survive, fill the remaining slots with candidates so BAT contributes 6 cards in total.

Winning is not enough — winning with your Rats intact is what banks material for the finale.